

Half-open files point toward pawns

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

A half-open file has no friendly pawn but contains an enemy pawn. It can guide rook pressure toward a fixed target. The target's defenders and the possibility of a pawn advance determine whether pressure can be increased.

WORKED EXAMPLE

After your c-pawn trades away, a rook on c1 may attack an enemy pawn on c7. If that pawn can advance safely to c5, it may escape the pressure and challenge your center instead.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How can you strengthen pressure against a half-open-file target?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Prevent its freeing advance, add another attacker, or force a defender away through a second threat. Do not pile up attackers without checking tactical counterplay.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A target is most useful when it cannot move out of danger.